TEXORA · COURSE NOTES · LECTURE SHEET

Social Stratification

How every society ranks its members in layers — the factors that fix a person's rank, the great contrast between caste and class, and the movements of people between layers: mobility and migration.

HUM-2209 · SOCIOLOGY AND HUMAN ECOLOGY · TOPIC 4 · LEVEL 2 TERM 2

1. Definition and basic features

Social stratification is the division of a society into ranked layers (strata) of people who have unequal amounts of wealth, power and prestige, together with the system of beliefs that justifies the ranking. The geological metaphor is deliberate: like rock strata, the layers lie one above another, and a person's layer shapes his whole life — his schooling, health, occupation, marriage and even life expectancy.

Its main features, as listed by Gisbert and standard texts:

- **It is social** — rank is assigned by society's evaluation, not by biological difference alone; a strong man is not thereby a high-ranking man.
- **It is universal but variable** — every known society ranks its members, yet the basis and steepness of ranking differ widely.
- **It is ancient** — present from the earliest chiefdoms onward; no historical society has been fully equal.
- **It is consequential** — the unequal distribution of life chances is its real meaning: strata differ in what their members can expect of life.
- **It exists in diverse forms** — slavery, estate, caste and class, described below.

2. Factors (bases) of stratification

FACTOR	HOW IT RANKS PEOPLE
Wealth and income	Ownership of land, capital and property, and the earnings they bring — the most visible modern basis.
Occupation	Jobs carry prestige as well as pay; the surgeon's occupation outranks the sweeper's in nearly every public ranking ever surveyed.

Education	Qualifications open occupations and certify status; unequal schooling is the great modern transmitter of unequal rank.
Power	The ability to make decisions binding on others — political office, administrative and managerial authority (Weber's “party” dimension).
Prestige / status honour	Social esteem attached to birth, occupation, lifestyle or achievement — Weber's “status” dimension; can diverge from wealth, as with the poor but honoured schoolteacher.
Birth and caste	Rank fixed at birth by descent — the basis of the caste system, below.
Race, ethnicity, religion	Group memberships used in many societies to assign superior and inferior positions.
Gender and age	Most societies have ranked men above women and elders above the young (or, in modern youth-centred settings, partly the reverse).

Max Weber's three dimensions — **class** (economic position), **status** (prestige) and **party** (power) — remain the standard analysis: a person's overall rank is a blend of the three, and they need not coincide.

3. Forms of stratification

- **Slavery** — the extreme form: some persons are the legal property of others. Rank is total, hereditary and enforced by law; now abolished in law everywhere, though illegal forms persist.
- **Estate** — the legal hierarchy of feudal Europe: clergy, nobility and commoners, each with defined rights and duties; movement between estates was rare but not absolutely barred.
- **Caste** — the hereditary, endogamous, occupation-bound hierarchy associated above all with Hindu India and present in echoes across South Asia.
- **Class** — the open, achievement-based layering of modern industrial societies.

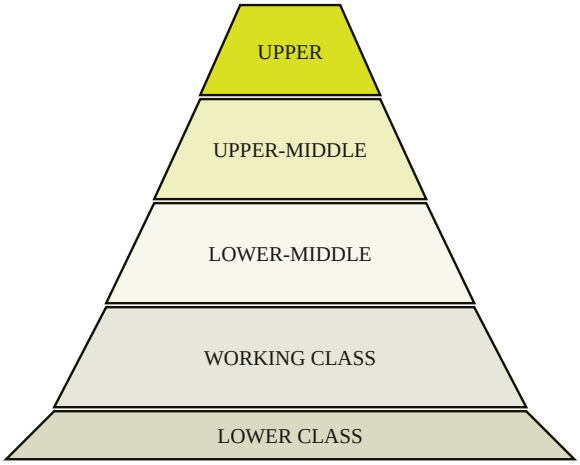


Figure 1 — The class pyramid of a typical industrial society: few at the top, the great mass in the lower-middle and working layers. (Schematic — proportions vary by society.)

4. Caste and class compared

POINT	CASTE	CLASS
Basis of rank	Birth and descent; religious sanction (karma, purity and pollution)	Wealth, occupation, education — economic achievement
Membership	Ascribed at birth; cannot be changed in this life	Achieved; can rise or fall within one lifetime
Mobility	Blocked — the system is closed	Open in principle — movement up and down is expected
Marriage	Endogamous — must marry within the caste	No formal bar; partners usually chosen from a similar class in practice
Occupation	Fixed by birth, hereditary	Chosen, though chances are unequal
Social relations	Rules of purity govern contact, food and touch across castes	No ritual bars on contact; inequality is economic and social, not ritual
Where found	Traditionally India and South Asia; echoes wherever descent fixes occupation	Modern industrial and urban societies worldwide

Real societies mix the two. Urban Bangladesh is class-organised in its factories and offices, yet birth, family name and inherited occupation still whisper in marriage choices and village standing — a live example of an open system carrying a closed system's remains.

5. Social mobility

Social mobility is the movement of individuals or groups from one social position to another. Its types:

- **Horizontal mobility** — change of position at the same level: a primary-school teacher becomes a madrasa teacher; no gain or loss of rank.
- **Vertical mobility** — movement up (**upward**) or down (**downward**) the ladder: a worker's daughter becomes a doctor (upward); a ruined merchant becomes a clerk (downward).
- **Intergenerational mobility** — change between parents' and children's positions: the standard measure of how open a society is.
- **Intragenerational mobility** — change within one person's own career.

Mobility is helped by education, urbanisation, industrial growth, legal equality and migration; it is hindered by caste, inherited wealth gaps, discrimination, and schooling that quietly reproduces the parents' rank. A society with high mobility is not necessarily an equal one — but its members at least believe the ladder can be climbed, and that belief itself stabilises the system.

6. Migration

Migration is the movement of people from one place to another with the intention of settling, for a period long enough to change their social life. Its main types:

- **Internal** (within the country — above all rural → urban) and **international** (across borders).
- **Voluntary** (seeking work, education, a better life) and **forced** (refugees fleeing war, persecution or disaster).
- From the sending place's view it is **emigration** (out) and **immigration** (in) for the receiving place.

Everett Lee's classic analysis divides the causes into **push factors** driving people out — landlessness and too little land, lack of rural jobs, river erosion and flood (a real and recurring cause in deltaic Bangladesh), poverty — and **pull factors** drawing them in — factory jobs, higher wages, education, hospitals, the bright reputation of the capital. Between them lie intervening obstacles: cost, distance, law and information.

The consequences run both ways. The receiving city gains labour and energy but strains housing, water and transport — Dhaka's growth is the national example. The sending village loses young workers but gains remittances and new ideas carried home. For the migrant himself, migration is usually also **social mobility**: the village labourer's son who becomes a Gazipur machine operator, then a line chief, has climbed in place and in rank together — which is why, despite every hardship, the flow does not stop.

7. Glossary — key terms of this topic

TERM	MEANING
Stratification	The ranking of a society's members into unequal layers of wealth, power and prestige.
Caste	A hereditary, endogamous, occupationally fixed stratum sanctioned by religion; a closed system.
Class	A stratum defined by economic position, membership achieved and changeable; an open system.
Endogamy	The rule requiring marriage within one's own group.
Social mobility	Movement of persons or groups between social positions — horizontal or vertical, within or between generations.
Push / pull factors	Conditions driving people out of a place / attracting them to another (Lee's analysis of migration).
Life chances	The opportunities a stratum's members typically have for education, health, occupation and longevity.

8. Key points and summary

- Stratification is universal, social and consequential: rank is assigned on blends of wealth, occupation, education, power, prestige, birth and group membership (Weber: class, status, party).
- Its historical forms are slavery, estate, caste and class; caste is closed and birth-fixed, class open and achievement-based — the comparison table is the heart of this topic.
- Mobility — horizontal/vertical, inter/intragenerational — measures how open a system really is.
- Migration, driven by push and pull factors, redistributes people between strata and places; in Bangladesh the rural-to-city flow into industry is the central case.

9. Practice

Answer in your own words; brief model answers follow.

1. “Stratification is universal but variable.” Explain in four sentences with one example of each half.
2. A poor village schoolteacher is greeted with more respect than a rich but ill-reputed trader. Use Weber's three dimensions to explain how this is possible.
3. A Brahmin's son becomes a clerk; a clerk's son becomes a company director. Which movement is mobility and which is not? Justify using the caste/class distinction.

4. Classify the mobility: (a) a nurse becomes a hospital administrator; (b) a bus driver becomes a taxi driver; (c) a farmer's grandson becomes a university lecturer; (d) a factory owner, bankrupted, becomes a security guard.
5. A young man leaves a river-eroded village in Barisal for a Gazipur garment factory. List two push and two pull factors in his case, then name one consequence for the village and one for the city.
6. Why does high mobility not necessarily mean high equality? Answer in three or four sentences.

Answer key

1. Every society ever studied ranks its members — none is perfectly equal (universal). But the basis and steepness vary (variable): rank by sacred birth in caste India, by examination and salary in a modern civil service — different ladders, different gaps.
2. Class (economic position) favours the trader; status (prestige/honour) favours the teacher, whose occupation and learning carry esteem; party (power) may favour neither much. Weber's point is that the three dimensions are independent, so overall standing can contradict wealth alone.
3. The clerk's son rising to director is mobility — class position changed by achievement. The Brahmin's son becoming a clerk is not caste mobility: his caste rank remains Brahmin whatever his occupation; only his class position moved. Caste membership itself is immovable.
4. (a) Vertical upward, intragenerational. (b) Horizontal. (c) Vertical upward, intergenerational. (d) Vertical downward, intragenerational.
5. Push: loss of land to erosion; no year-round work in the village. Pull: steady factory wages in Gazipur; chances of training, promotion and urban services. Village consequence: loss of young labour but remittance income. City consequence: labour supply grows while housing and utilities strain further.
6. Mobility measures movement between positions, equality measures the distance between them. A society can let people climb briskly up and down a very tall ladder; the gaps in income, schooling and health between top and bottom may still be enormous.
